

Q How can exercise make my pregnancy easier?

If you are one of the 70 percent or so of women who experience backaches and other physical discomfort in pregnancy, you may think that resting will help. Instead, practice safe, low-impact exercises to decrease the muscle spasms.

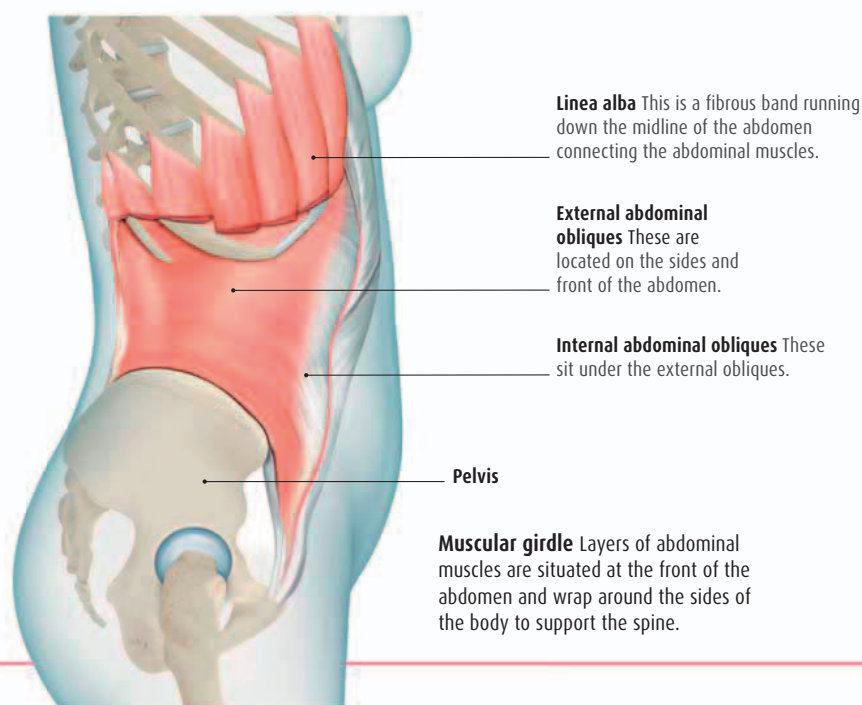
It's not just the extra weight of your baby as she grows that puts a strain on areas such as your back. The aches you experience increase because the hormone relaxin loosens your ligaments, especially those in your pelvic cradle. This makes way for your growing baby and prepares for birth; in fact all your ligaments soften due to the high concentrations of relaxin required to loosen the pelvic joints. Your baby's increasing size also stretches the transversus abdominis (TVA) muscles, which act like a girdle to support and stabilize your lower back from the sides and front. As your center of gravity shifts forward with the baby's weight, it's

likely that your posture will change to compensate, increasing the strain on muscles in your lower back. It may be tempting to lie down when you ache, but any exercise that helps you strengthen these deep transversus abdominis muscles will ease the pain or discomfort. Consider prenatal Pilates classes, which specifically target your "core stability"—strengthening these core muscles so that your back remains as steady and supported as possible—or try the exercises shown opposite. These gentle stretching and strengthening movements will decrease muscle spasms, release back tension, and improve your spinal flexibility.

Any exercise that helps **strengthen the transversus abdominis muscles** will ease pain and discomfort.

TRANSVERSUS ABDOMINIS MUSCLES

This "core" of deep abdominal muscles lies beneath the outer muscles (such as rectus abdominis, or the "six pack"). They wrap around the spine and help to stabilize your torso and lower back. The stronger the transversus abdominis muscles are, the more support they give.



Q How do I ease the symptoms of water retention?

There are a couple of options you can try if you are experiencing water retention, or edema, in your ankles, feet, and hands, or if your joints are feeling stiff. One of the best choices is to walk around for a while every so often during the day to get your circulation going (avoid sitting or standing still for long periods), or go for a daily walk outdoors, or swim. Swimming has the added benefit of cooling your body down in hot weather; becoming too hot can cause water retention. Elevating your feet can help, too. Use a foot stool if you work at a desk, or elevate your feet properly for a while: sit back in a chair, raise your feet right up, and rotate your ankles several times in each direction to get the blood flowing.

Complementary therapies

Massage can be very beneficial in helping to dissipate fluid and reduce tension. For a home massage, gently massage your feet, ankles, and lower legs with a lotion or cooling gel; use upward strokes working toward your knees. If you are heavily pregnant, you may find it easier to ask your partner to do this. When massaging your hands, press firmly from your nails to the base of your fingers. Reflexology and acupuncture can also help; your practitioner may be able to show you acupressure points to use in between visits.

Water retention often occurs during the last three months of pregnancy due in part to the extra blood—up to 50 percent more than usual—that you produce. It also occurs if you are dehydrated, as your body tries to retain as much fluid as possible, so drink plenty of water.

When you exercise, make sure that you wear clothing that gives you a **full range of movement** and choose suitable footwear that will **support** your ankles and feet. Keep drinking plenty of water and take regular rest breaks.